



# The Lewis

A cramp, and a son

SYMBOLISM

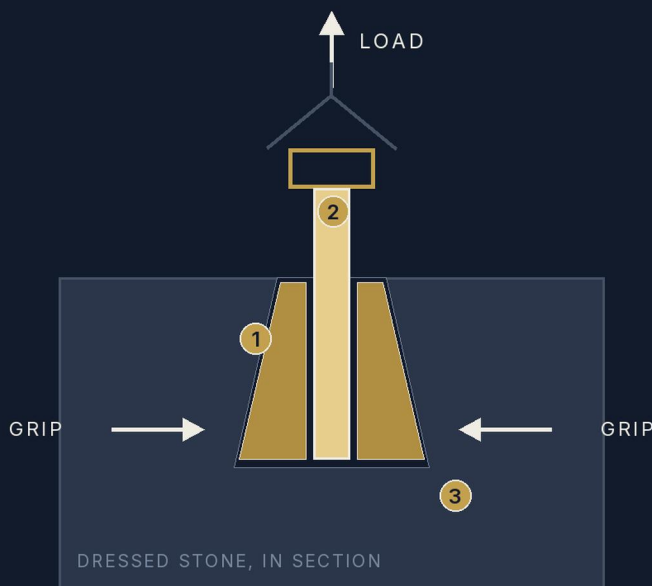
An iron device for lifting dressed stone, and the word we give to a mason's son. One object, one pun, and one genuine obligation.

## ON THE TABLE

A lewis, if the lodge has one; the Junior Warden's pedestal if not

### THE LEWIS

Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The outer wedges splay into the undercut; the centre key drops between them and forces them apart. The heavier the stone, the tighter the grip.



- 1 outer wedge
- 2 centre key, dropped in last
- 3 dovetail, wider at the bottom

Lift, and the key drives the wedges outward into the undercut — the load itself is what makes it hold. There is no catch to fail and no knot to slip.

Set the stone down and the tension comes off. The key lifts out, the wedges fall slack, and the lewis is free — leaving a small dovetailed hole that the next course covers for ever.

Diagram drawn for The Vulcan Papers.

## HOW THE PAPER RUNS

|      |                                       |
|------|---------------------------------------|
| 0:00 | Opening                               |
| 1:00 | The iron                              |
| 3:30 | Where you will see it in this room    |
| 5:00 | The son                               |
| 6:30 | The privilege, and what is left of it |
| 8:00 | Why this is the best symbol we own    |
| 9:30 | Closing                               |

## THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The heavier the stone, the tighter the grip.
- 2 A lewis is also a mason's son, charged to bear the burden his parents should be exempt from.
- 3 Under UGLE a lewis gets no precedence and no early admission. He gets a name and an expectation.



IF YOU ARE ASKED

How does a lewis work?

Three pieces of iron in a dovetailed hole. The outer wedges splay into the undercut; the centre piece locks them. The load tightens the grip.

Can a lewis be initiated younger?

Not under UGLE. Twenty-one, or eighteen by dispensation, the same as anyone. Other constitutions vary.

Does a lewis get initiated first?

Historically a recognised privilege; not a right under UGLE today.

Where is it in the lodge?

Holding the perfect ashlar on its tripod, and named on the First Degree tracing board.

SOURCES

- Emulation Ritual — the First Degree tracing board explanation
- Harry Carr, The Freemason at Work — on the lewis, its privileges and the variations between constitutions
- UGLE Book of Constitutions — age of candidates
- Knoop & Jones, The Mediaeval Mason — lifting tackle and operative practice

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

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